

First 72 Hours in Tokyo

The calm, no-guesswork arrival kit — from the airport to your first three days

*Made by a resident of the Tokyo area. Prices and rules were checked against official sources where possible — anything marked approx. should be double-checked before you travel. **Last verified: 2026-10-05***

How to use this kit

1. **7 days before you fly** → do the "Before You Fly" checklist (Section 1). It takes about 30 minutes.
2. **On the plane** → read "Landing" for your airport (Narita or Haneda) and pick your route.
3. **Days 1–3** → pick the route that matches your hotel area.

Prices change. Where you see *approx.*, double-check the official website before you go.

1. Before You Fly — 30-minute checklist

- ☐ **Register on Visit Japan Web** (free, run by Japan's Digital Agency). One QR code covers immigration and customs. It is optional — paper forms still exist — but it makes arrival faster.
- ☐ **Set up mobile data.** Buy an eSIM before you leave so your phone works the moment you land (maps, translation, train apps).
- ☐ **Decide how you'll pay for trains:**

- iPhone user → the **Welcome Suica Mobile** app: no deposit, balance valid for 180 days from your first top-up. You top up through Apple Pay with a card in your own name. Some countries have restrictions, so test it before you fly.
 - Android user, or you want a physical card → buy a Suica or PASMO card at the station. Card sales resumed in March 2025.
 - ☐ **Shopping plans? Read Section 5 now.** Japan's tax-free system changed on **November 1, 2026**.
 - ☐ **Save these numbers in your phone:**
 - Police **110** / Ambulance & Fire **119**
 - **Japan Visitor Hotline** (24/7, English available): +81-50-3816-2787
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2. Landing: Narita (NRT)

Narita is about an hour from central Tokyo. Choose by **where your hotel is** and **how tired you are**.

Option	To	Time	Price (adult)	Best for
Skyliner (Keisei)	Ueno / Nippori	41 min to Ueno	¥2,470 (IC: ¥2,465)	Hotels in Ueno, Asakusa, Akihabara. Fastest
Access Express (Keisei)	Ueno, Asakusa line	Slower than the Skyliner	¥1,240 (IC: ¥1,235)	Saving money, light luggage
N'EX (JR) round trip	Tokyo, Shinjuku, Shibuya and more	—	¥5,200 round trip, valid 14 days, foreign passport only	Hotels on the JR lines (Shinjuku, Shibuya, Tokyo)
Airport bus	Tokyo Station, Ginza	From 65 min to Tokyo Station	¥1,500 daytime / ¥3,000 late night	Heavy luggage, no transfers

Simple rule:

- Hotel in the **east** (Ueno, Asakusa) → Skyliner
- Hotel in the **west** (Shinjuku, Shibuya) → N'EX round trip, if you also fly out from Narita
- **Big suitcases, late arrival** → bus

3. Landing: Haneda (HND)

Haneda is close to the city — most travelers reach a central station in under 20 minutes.

Option	To	Time	Price (IC card, adult)
Keikyu Line	Shinagawa	11–14 min	approx. ¥330
Tokyo Monorail	Hamamatsucho	approx. 13 min	approx. ¥519

Simple rule: Keikyu if your hotel is south or west (Shinagawa, Shibuya). Monorail if you're heading toward Tokyo Station, Ginza or Hamamatsucho.

4. Getting around: your first 72 hours

Tokyo Subway Ticket — unlimited rides on all Tokyo Metro and Toei Subway lines:

Pass	Adult	Child (6–11)
24 hours	¥1,000	¥500
48 hours	¥1,500	¥750
72 hours	¥2,000	¥1,000

The clock starts the first time you go through a ticket gate — not when you buy the pass.

Is it worth it? The cheapest Tokyo Metro ride costs ¥178 with an IC card. On a sightseeing day with 5 or more subway rides, the 24-hour pass usually pays for itself. On a slow first day, pay as you go with your Suica.

 The pass does **not** cover JR lines (such as the Yamanote Line).

5. Shopping: the new tax-free system (from November 1, 2026)

What changed:

1. **You now pay the full price, tax included, at the store.**
2. Keep your goods and your passport together.
3. **Within 90 days of purchase**, at your departure airport, go to the tax-free kiosk in the **international departure lobby — before you check in your bags**. Scan your passport and complete the customs check.
4. Once customs confirms the goods are leaving Japan, you get the tax back.
5. **No customs check = no refund.**

Other points:

- You still need to spend approx. ¥5,000 or more (before tax) per store, per day.
- Consumables (cosmetics, snacks) no longer need special sealed bags.

Pro tip: Pack tax-free items in your carry-on, or keep them easy to reach. Customs may ask to see them **before** your suitcase goes into the hold.

6. Day plans (pick the one that matches your hotel)

Day 1 — Arrival day: stay close, stay easy

- Check in, walk 10 minutes around your hotel, have dinner at the nearest busy local restaurant.
- Buy water and breakfast at a convenience store (konbini) for tomorrow morning.
- Go to bed early. Jet lag can easily ruin day 2.

Day 2 — East Tokyo (traditional side) Asakusa (morning, before the crowds) → Ueno (park and museums) → Akihabara (evening) *A 24-hour Subway Ticket fits this day well.*

Day 3 — West Tokyo (modern side) Harajuku → Shibuya → Shinjuku (night views) *These areas are on the JR Yamanote Line, which the Subway Ticket doesn't cover. Use your Suica.*

7. Everyday survival notes

- **Trash cans are rare on the street.** Carry a small bag for your trash and throw it away at your hotel or at a konbini.
 - **Eating while walking** is frowned upon in many areas. Eat near the shop where you bought the food.
 - **Trains:** stand in line at the marked spots on the platform, and keep phone calls off.
 - **Cash:** many places take cards, but keep some yen for small shops and temples.
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8. Printable checklist

Before you fly

- ☐ Visit Japan Web registered
- ☐ eSIM installed
- ☐ Train payment decided (Welcome Suica Mobile or physical card)
- ☐ Emergency numbers saved

Arrival day

- ☐ Route from the airport chosen (Section 2 or 3)
- ☐ Konbini breakfast for day 2 bought

Before you leave Japan

- ☐ Tax-free items within 90 days of purchase
- ☐ Tax-free kiosk **before** bag check-in
- ☐ Passport ready

This kit is general travel information, not professional advice. Prices and rules can change — always check the official website before you travel. Made with the help of AI tools, then checked by a person living in the Tokyo area.